

Do you have access to “pocket listings” or off-market deals?

As we discussed earlier, the best deals don't sit on the market for very long. A great agent will know many of the local listing agents in your area, so they might have advance knowledge of deals that have yet to hit the market. This kind of networking gives you a big advantage in the home-buying process, since it may allow you to begin researching certain deals before they make it to the public eye—which prepares you to make an offer sooner than the competition.

If the agent responds positively to this question, try to scope out how they get access to these off-market or premarket deals and how many usually pop up. If they don't have this kind of access, that's not necessarily a bad thing. It's more of a special bonus than an absolute requirement.

Only the best-networked agents will have access to off-market or premarket deals, and they are likely the busiest. It's even more important that you demonstrate how ready, willing, and able you are to commit when working with agents who have an incredible local network. These top-notch agents won't want the business of “tire kickers.”

How easy are you to reach? What is your preferred method of communication?

Though it seems like common sense, this is a key factor. While you may have a long purchase timeline, you are looking for a very specific deal to pop on the market. You need to be ready to react immediately when such a property comes online, so it's very important that your agent pick up when you call them, or that they at least call you back in a timely manner.

Of course, anyone could easily answer, “I sleep with my phone!” (If they say, “Oh, I never really answer. I hardly remember to charge my phone and live in a bad reception area,” congratulate them for their boldness and honesty, then make your timely exit.) A good way to gauge the responsiveness of your agent is to call them to set up a meeting and follow up with an email a few hours after your call. If you get a timely response on both attempts, then you have two signs pointing to great communication practices from your agent. If there is a significant delay, you have a piece of information to tuck away in your decision-making process.

As far as the method of communication goes, some younger agents prefer to work only by text, which is great if that's also what you prefer.